What came as a bonus was a NASA fellowship I had applied for while at Princeton. The Government of India's monthly sustenance allowance was $210; the NASA fellowship entitled me for $460. That was big money, which would not come to me directly. NASA would send the money to the Government of India, which had to pass it on to me.

The Government of India promptly received my NASA fellowship money of $460 every month, but gave me only $210, citing some bureaucratic rigmarole. It was only much later after my return to India, and again thanks to Sarabhai's interference, I got those arrears. After my return, I asked Sarabhai's administration head S R Thakur why I was not given the money. He said he tried hard for six months, but could not get it passed. I went on a strike of sorts and stayed away from Sarabhai's meetings, but continued with my work.

After three meetings, Sarabhai sent word. I said I am unhappy that I am not paid my dues. Sarabhai dictated a letter to the first stenographer in sight, saying I be paid the money immediately, whatever it takes, signed it and asked Thakur to process it. Thakur was visibly upset that what he could not do despite six months of efforts Sarabhai could do immediately. But Sarabhai doesn't take such questions. The letter went up to the Prime Minister's office for ratification, and I got my money. I still have a copy of Sarabhai's letter sanctioning the money—and I consider that invaluable.

At Princeton, I was not worried about the extra money since $210 was good enough, and I had a few friends who made life happier. One of them was S N Gupta, a graduate from IIT Kanpur working on a Princeton project on the behaviour of aircraft during turbulence. A trained pilot that he was, Gupta probably had the most adventurous learning on the campus. When the weather is bad and the winds gusty, Gupta would hop into the cockpit of the small aircraft on the campus and fly into the darkest of clouds.

Sometimes Gupta would ask me to accompany him. First hesitantly, later eagerly, I would get into the cockpit with him. He would look out for the toughest patches in the sky to guide his flying machine through. I thought of the bumpy flight from Trivandrum to Madras, from which most